

cases can be achieved in less than 10 years, and in some, less than 5.

It all boils down to personal choice and priorities. Would you rather live large in small bursts for the rest of your life (or at least until old age), or have the power to completely check out of societal expectations and live large full-time at a younger age? Only you can answer that question, and the answer is different for all of us, as is the financial path and method. But if you are serious about removing rent and mortgage overhead, the 12 methods mentioned above should give you some ideas for where and how to start. — **Myscha Theriault**

20 Tips for Getting Your Security Deposit Back

Although most of my landlords have been really great, I did have one a couple of years back who pulled the security deposit trick on all her tenants.

Before moving out, I cleaned that apartment from top to bottom, bleaching the mold that formed in the closets (it was there when I moved in, and I battled it monthly), relining the cupboards with that stick-on liner so they were clean and fresh-looking. My boyfriend helped me to repair a shelf that had completely collapsed in the closet. I never wore shoes in the house, so the carpet was spotless.

When I left, I somehow managed to forget a bicycle tire on my balcony, a spare tire that I had been meaning to patch. The balcony was so moldy and terrifying that I rarely stepped out on it, and simply forgot that the tire was there.

I was charged \$75 for its disposal. And that's *on top of* the nonrefundable cleaning service.

